GENERATIVE AI & AGENTIC AI · LESSON 4 OF 12

Embeddings and Vector Search: Meaning as Numbers, Similarity and Vector Databases

Learn the foundation of semantic search and RAG. What embeddings are, how word and sentence embeddings are learned (trained here from scratch on our reviews), cosine similarity, document embeddings, building a vector index, exact vs approximate nearest-neighbour search (IVF, HNSW), evaluating retrieval with recall@k, hybrid keyword + vector search, and choosing embedding models and vector databases.

GenAI Launchpad

✦ 2026 tooling: Voyage, OpenAI, Gemini embeddings · pgvector · FAISS · Chroma

Intermediate

⏱ 110 min

By the end of this lesson you can

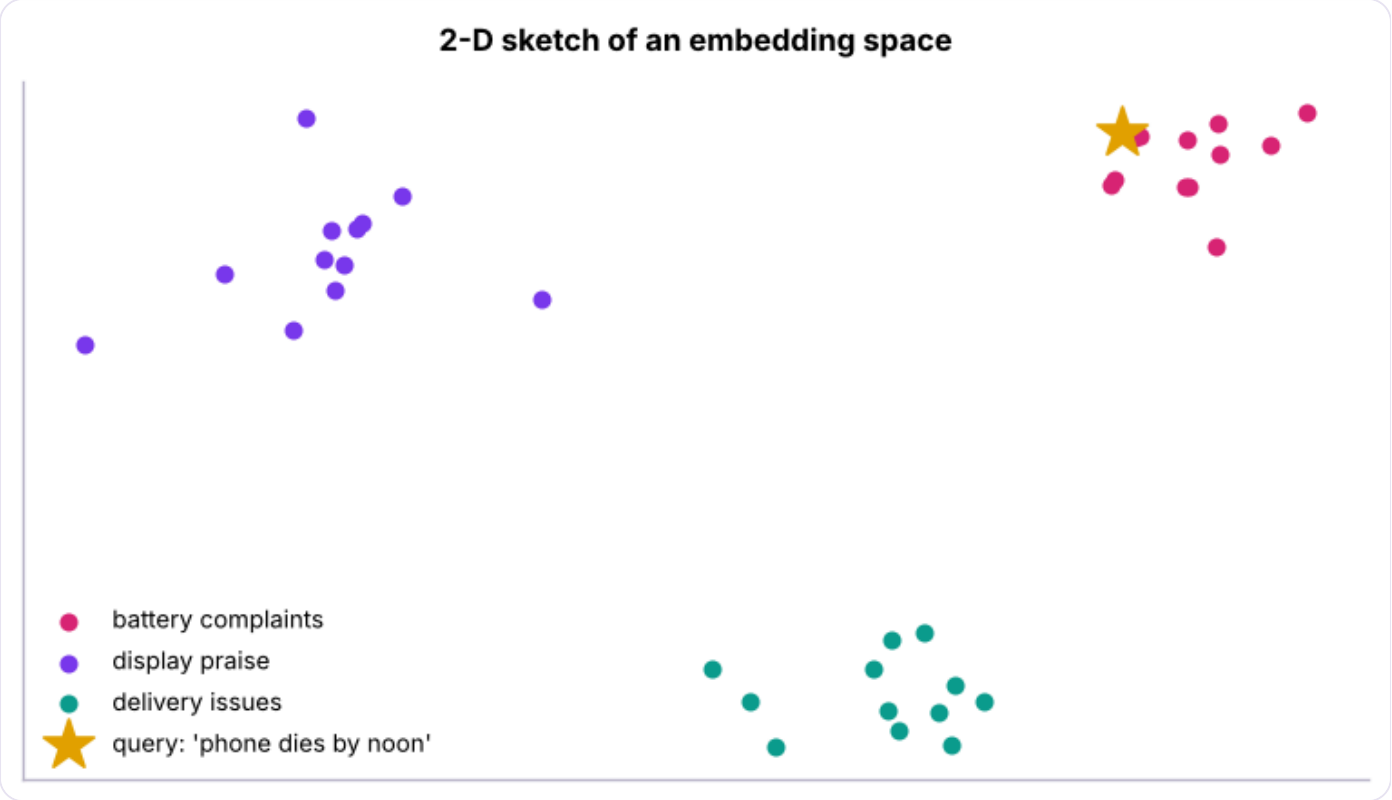
- Explain embeddings and why similar meanings produce nearby vectors
- Learn word embeddings from co-occurrence and build document embeddings
- Use cosine similarity and build exact and approximate vector indexes
- Measure retrieval quality with recall@k and latency
- Choose an embedding model, chunking strategy and vector store for an application

Datasets used

`customer_reviews.csv`

What is an embedding?

An **embedding** is a list of numbers (a vector) that represents the meaning of a word, sentence, image or product. Models are trained so that **similar meanings produce nearby vectors**.



Embeddings place items in a space where distance reflects meaning: complaints about charging cluster together, praise for displays clusters elsewhere.

Real embeddings have 256–3,072 dimensions. Uses: semantic search, RAG (next lesson), recommendations ("similar products"), clustering and de-duplication, classification features, anomaly detection.

Learning word embeddings from scratch

"You shall know a word by the company it keeps" (J. R. Firth). Words that appear in similar contexts get similar vectors. Word2Vec and GloVe learn this with neural networks; the classic **PPMI + SVD** method below captures the same idea in a few lines.

Python

```
import re, collections, pandas as pd
from sklearn.decomposition import TruncatedSVD
from scipy.sparse import coo_matrix
rv = pd.read_csv("customer_reviews.csv")
docs = [re.findall(r"[a-z]+", t.lower()) for t in rv.review_text]
counts = collections.Counter(w for d in docs for w in d)
vocab = [w for w, c in counts.items() if c ⩾ 5]; idx = {w: i for i, w in enumerate(vocab)}
pairs = collections.Counter()
for d in docs:
    ids = [idx[w] for w in d if w in idx]
    for i, a in enumerate(ids):
        for b in ids[max(0, i - 3): i] + ids[i + 1: i + 4]: pairs[a, b] += 1      # co-
occurrence within ±3 words
r, c, v = zip(*[(a, b, n) for (a, b), n in pairs.items()])
M = coo_matrix((v, (r, c)), shape=(len(vocab), len(vocab))).tocsr().astype(float)
total = M.sum(); row = np.asarray(M.sum(1)).ravel(); col = np.asarray(M.sum(0)).ravel()
M = M.tocoo(); pmi = np.log((M.data * total) / (row[M.row] * col[M.col])); keep = pmi > 0
PPMI = coo_matrix((pmi[keep], (M.row[keep], M.col[keep])), shape=M.shape).tocsr()
W = TruncatedSVD(50, random_state=0).fit_transform(PPMI); W /= np.linalg.norm(W, axis=1,
keepdims=True)
def similar(word, k=6):
    s = W @ W[idx[word]]; return [vocab[i] for i in np.argsort(-s)[1:k + 1]]
print(len(vocab), "words, 50-dimensional vectors")
for w in ["battery", "delivery", "superb", "slow", "refund"]: print(f"{w:9s} →
{similar(w)}")
```

OUTPUT

```
213 words, 50-dimensional vectors
battery   → ['batery', 'lasts', 'day', 'barely', 'half', 'a']
delivery  → ['delivry', 'was', 'courier', 'replacement', 'buttons', 'packaging']
superb    → ['highly', 'bahut', 'loved', 'recommend', 'badiya', 'rich']
slow      → ['painfully', 'times', 'is', 'charging', 'disappointed', 'this']
refund    → ['still', 'has', 'pending', 'display', 'charging', 'courier']
```

Even this small corpus learns useful structure: "battery" sits near "lasts", "barely" and "half (a day)", "superb" near "loved", "highly" and "recommend", and "slow" near "painfully" and "charging". It even links the misspelling "batery" to "battery". But it only knows words that appear in these 3,000 reviews. Modern embedding models learn from billions of sentences, so they also know that "phone dies by noon" means poor battery life.

Cosine similarity

$$\cos(\mathbf{a}, \mathbf{b}) = \frac{\mathbf{a} \cdot \mathbf{b}}{\|\mathbf{a}\| \, \|\mathbf{b}\|}$$

1 = same direction (same meaning), 0 = unrelated, −1 = opposite. With **normalised** vectors (length 1), cosine similarity is just the dot product, which is why vector databases normalise embeddings.

Python

```
def cos(a, b): return float(a @ b / (np.linalg.norm(a) * np.linalg.norm(b)))
for a, b in [("battery", "lasts"), ("delivery", "courier"), ("superb", "loved"), ("superb",
"slow")]: print(f"cos({a}, {b}) = {cos(W[idx[a]], W[idx[b]]):.2f}")
```

OUTPUT

```
cos(battery, lasts) = 0.75
cos(delivery, courier) = 0.60
cos(superb, loved) = 0.78
cos(superb, slow) = 0.05
```

Document embeddings and semantic search

A simple document vector: the TF-IDF-weighted average of its word vectors. (Sentence-embedding models do this far better with a transformer.)

Python

```python
from sklearn.feature_extraction.text import TfidfVectorizer
tf = TfidfVectorizer(vocabulary=vocab, token_pattern=r"[a-
z]+").fit(rv.review_text.str.lower())
def embed(texts):
    T = tf.transform([t.lower() for t in texts]); D = T @ W
    return D / np.maximum(np.linalg.norm(D, axis=1, keepdims=True), 1e-9)
E = embed(rv.review_text.tolist())
def search(query, k=4):
    s = E @ embed([query])[0]; out, seen = [], set()
    for i in np.argsort(-s):                                    # skip duplicate texts
        txt = rv.review_text.iloc[i].rstrip(".!:) ")
        if txt.lower() in seen: continue
        seen.add(txt.lower()); out.append((round(float(s[i]), 2), txt[:80]))
        if len(out) == k: break
    return out
for q in ["charging takes forever", "parcel came late and broken", "support team was very
helpful"]:
    print("query:", q); [print("   ", r) for r in search(q)]
```

OUTPUT

```
query: charging takes forever
    (0.85, 'Charging is painfully slow')
    (0.78, 'Regret buying this. Charging is painfully slow')
    (0.78, 'Very disappointed. Charging is painfully slow')
    (0.77, 'Charging is painfully slow, not worth it')
query: parcel came late and broken
    (0.86, 'Delivery was totally late')
    (0.82, 'Very disappointed. Delivery was late')
    (0.8, 'Bekaar product. Delivery was late')
    (0.79, 'Sound is tinny, delivery was super late, not worth it')
query: support team was very helpful
    (0.79, 'Superb product. Price is very totally reasonable for these features,
customer su')
    (0.77, 'Highly recommend. Packaging was very neat and safe, battery backup is
superb, cu')
    (0.77, 'Bahut badiya. Packaging was really neat and safe, service centre staff
were supe')
    (0.75, 'Highly recommend. Service centre staff were helpful, charges really very
fast')
```

Vector indexes: exact and approximate search

Comparing a query with every vector (**exact / brute-force** search) is fine for thousands of items. For millions, use **approximate nearest neighbour (ANN)** indexes that check only promising regions.

Python

```python
import time
rng = np.random.default_rng(0)
N, d = 100_000, 64
centres = rng.normal(size=(2000, d))                                    # real embeddings
are clustered by topic, not uniform
X = (centres[rng.integers(0, 2000, N)] + rng.normal(0, .35, (N, d))).astype(np.float32); X
/= np.linalg.norm(X, axis=1, keepdims=True)
queries = X[rng.choice(N, 100, replace=False)] + rng.normal(0, .05, (100,
d)).astype(np.float32)
t0 = time.perf_counter(); exact = np.argsort(-(queries @ X.T), axis=1)[:, :10]; t_exact =
time.perf_counter() - t0
from sklearn.cluster import MiniBatchKMeans
nlist = 256; km = MiniBatchKMeans(nlist, random_state=0, n_init=3, batch_size=4096).fit(X)
# IVF: partition vectors into cells
assign = km.labels_; cells = {c: np.where(assign == c)[0] for c in range(nlist)}
def ivf_search(q, nprobe=8, k=10):
    near = np.argsort(-(km.cluster_centers_ @ q))[:nprobe]; cand = np.concatenate([cells[c]
for c in near])
    return cand[np.argsort(-(X[cand] @ q))[:k]]
for nprobe in (1, 4, 16):
    t0 = time.perf_counter(); approx = np.array([ivf_search(q, nprobe) for q in queries]);
t = time.perf_counter() - t0
    recall = np.mean([len(set(a) & set(e)) / 10 for a, e in zip(approx, exact)])
    print(f"IVF nprobe={nprobe:2d}: recall@10 {recall:.2f} | {1000 * t / 100:.2f} ms/query
(exact: {1000 * t_exact / 100:.2f} ms/query)")
```

OUTPUT

```
IVF nprobe= 1: recall@10 0.89 | 0.08 ms/query (exact: 2.12 ms/query)
IVF nprobe= 4: recall@10 0.98 | 0.19 ms/query (exact: 2.12 ms/query)
IVF nprobe=16: recall@10 1.00 | 0.81 ms/query (exact: 2.12 ms/query)
```

Index	Idea	Trade-off
Flat (exact)	Compare with everything	Perfect recall, slow at scale
IVF	Cluster vectors; search a few nearest clusters (`nprobe`)	Tune recall vs speed
HNSW	Navigable small-world graph of neighbours	Very fast, high recall, more memory
Product quantisation (PQ)	Compress vectors into short codes	Huge datasets in little memory

Libraries: **FAISS**, **hnswlib**, **ScaNN**, Annoy. In production, ANN indexes live inside vector databases.

Evaluate retrieval

Create a small labelled set of queries with their relevant documents and measure **recall@k** (share of relevant documents found in the top k) and **MRR** (how high the first relevant result ranks).

Python

```
aspect_rx = {"battery": r"batter|charg", "delivery": r"deliver|courier|box arrived|packag",
"service": r"support|service|refund|replacement|care"}
labelled = {"phone battery dies quickly": "battery", "my order came late": "delivery", "the
customer care was useless": "service"}
from sklearn.feature_extraction.text import TfidfVectorizer as TV
bm = TV(ngram_range=(1, 2), sublinear_tf=True).fit(rv.review_text); B =
bm.transform(rv.review_text)
def precision_at_k(scores, aspect, k=10):
    rel = rv.review_text.str.lower().str.contains(aspect_rx[aspect]).to_numpy(); top =
np.argsort(-scores)[:k]; return rel[top].mean()
for q, a in labelled.items():
    dense = E @ embed([q])[0]; sparse = (B @ bm.transform([q]).T).toarray().ravel()
    hybrid = 0.5 * dense / dense.max() + 0.5 * sparse / max(sparse.max(), 1e-9)
    print(f"{q:32s} precision@10 dense {precision_at_k(dense, a):.1f} | keyword
{precision_at_k(sparse, a):.1f} | hybrid {precision_at_k(hybrid, a):.1f}")
```

OUTPUT

```
phone battery dies quickly      precision@10 dense 0.8 | keyword 0.6 | hybrid 0.6
my order came late              precision@10 dense 0.3 | keyword 0.6 | hybrid 0.4
the customer care was useless   precision@10 dense 1.0 | keyword 1.0 | hybrid 1.0
```

No method wins every query: the small home-made embeddings beat keywords on "battery dies", keywords win on "order came late" (exact words such as "late"), and the hybrid lands in between. With strong embedding models on large real corpora, **hybrid search** (keyword/BM25 + vector, then optional re-ranking with a cross-encoder or LLM) is usually the most robust production choice: keywords catch exact terms (product codes, names), vectors catch paraphrases.

Real embedding models

Python

```python
# Voyage AI (recommended by Anthropic for use with Claude) - pip install voyageai
import voyageai
vo = voyageai.Client()                                    # VOYAGE_API_KEY in the
environment
docs_emb = vo.embed(texts, model="voyage-3.5", input_type="document").embeddings
query_emb = vo.embed(["phone dies by noon"], model="voyage-3.5",
input_type="query").embeddings[0]

# OpenAI - pip install openai
from openai import OpenAI
emb = OpenAI().embeddings.create(model="text-embedding-3-small", input=texts).data

# Local, free - pip install sentence-transformers
from sentence_transformers import SentenceTransformer
model = SentenceTransformer("BAAI/bge-small-en-v1.5")
emb = model.encode(texts, normalize_embeddings=True)
```

Check the MTEB leaderboard for quality by task and language (multilingual models handle Hindi and other Indian languages), and test on your own queries.

Vector stores

Option	When
NumPy / FAISS in memory	Prototypes, up to a few million vectors
pgvector (PostgreSQL), Supabase	You already run Postgres; combine SQL filters and vectors
Chroma, LanceDB	Simple local or embedded stores for apps and notebooks
Qdrant, Weaviate, Milvus	Dedicated open-source vector databases at scale
Pinecone, cloud search (Azure AI Search, Vertex Vector Search, OpenSearch)	Managed services

Python

```
# pgvector example
# CREATE EXTENSION vector;
# CREATE TABLE reviews (id bigserial PRIMARY KEY, text text, product text, embedding
vector(1024));
# CREATE INDEX ON reviews USING hnsw (embedding vector_cosine_ops);
# SELECT id, text FROM reviews WHERE product = 'Laptop' ORDER BY embedding ⟺ $1 LIMIT 5;
-- ⟺ is cosine distance
```

Practical tips

- **Chunk** long documents (e.g. 300–800 tokens with some overlap, split on headings/paragraphs) before embedding (lesson 5).
- Store **metadata** (source, date, product, access rights) with each vector and filter on it.
- Use the same model for documents and queries; re-embed everything when you change models.
- Normalise vectors; use cosine or dot product consistently.
- Cache embeddings: they are cheap but not free, and recomputing is slow.

Summary

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Embeddings map text (or images, products) to vectors where similar meanings are close.
- Word embeddings come from co-occurrence (Word2Vec, GloVe, PPMI-SVD); sentence embeddings from transformer models.
- Cosine similarity (dot product of normalised vectors) measures closeness.
- Exact search is simple; ANN indexes (IVF, HNSW, PQ) trade a little recall for big speed-ups.
- Evaluate retrieval with recall@k/MRR; combine keyword and vector search (hybrid) and re-rank.
- Choose embedding models by tested quality, language and cost; choose stores by scale and existing stack (pgvector is a common first choice).

Quick quiz

6 questions · tap an answer to check it

1. What property do good embeddings have?

- **A** Items with similar meanings have nearby vectors
- **B** Every vector is identical
- **C** They store the original text
- **D** They are always 2-D

Answer: A. Distance encodes meaning.

2. Cosine similarity of 1 means...

- **A** The vectors point in the same direction (very similar meaning)
- **B** Unrelated
- **C** Opposite
- **D** An error

Answer: A. Values range from −1 to 1.

3. Why use an approximate nearest-neighbour index?

- **A** To search millions of vectors fast with only a small loss of recall
- **B** To increase accuracy above exact search
- **C** To store text
- **D** To train embeddings

Answer: A. e.g. IVF or HNSW.

4. In an IVF index, increasing `nprobe` ...

- **A** Searches more clusters: higher recall, slower queries
- **B** Reduces recall
- **C** Changes the embeddings
- **D** Deletes vectors

Answer: A. A tunable trade-off.

5. Why combine keyword and vector search?

- **A** Keywords catch exact terms and codes; vectors catch paraphrases and synonyms
- **B** It is cheaper than either alone
- **C** Vectors cannot be filtered
- **D** Keywords understand meaning better

Answer: A. Hybrid search is the production default.

6. You switch to a new embedding model. What must you do?

- **A** Re-embed all documents with the new model
- **B** Nothing
- **C** Only re-embed queries
- **D** Delete the index

Answer: A. Vectors from different models are not comparable.

EXERCISE

Practice

(1) Find the 10 nearest words to "price" and "screen" in the learned vectors. (2) Cluster the review embeddings with K-means (k = 6) and label each cluster from its top words. (3) Measure how recall@10 changes with `nlist` 64 vs 1,024 at nprobe = 8. (4) Design a pgvector table for a product catalogue with metadata filters.

Show solution (worked answer)

Python

```
print(similar("price", 10), similar("screen", 10))
from sklearn.cluster import KMeans
lab = KMeans(6, n_init=10, random_state=0).fit_predict(E)
for c in range(6): print(c, collections.Counter(w for t in rv.review_text[lab == c]
for w in re.findall(r"[a-z]+", t.lower()) if w in idx and counts[w] <
600).most_common(5))
```

INTERVIEW CORNER

Questions you may be asked

Q: What is an embedding and how is it used in search? A dense vector representing meaning. Documents are embedded once and stored; a query is embedded at search time, and the nearest document vectors (by cosine similarity) are returned, often combined with keyword search.

Q: How does HNSW work at a high level? It builds a layered graph where each vector links to near neighbours; search starts at a coarse top layer and greedily moves closer to the query through lower layers, visiting only a small part of the data.

Q: How do you evaluate a semantic search system? A labelled set of queries with relevant documents; measure recall@k, precision@k, MRR or nDCG, plus latency and cost, and compare keyword, vector and hybrid configurations.

Practise more online

Free, trusted places to test yourself on this topic. Links open the original site in a new tab.